

TN.4 Where to File Directory

Tennessee publishes the answer — here is where the list lives, how to read it, and the one place the state contradicts itself.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Tennessee adopts one state residential code and then gives your jurisdiction three different ways to answer for it: run its own building department, let the State Fire Marshal enforce the state code through contract inspectors, or opt out entirely so that no residential building code is enforced at all. The unit is the **jurisdiction**, not the county — a city inside an opted-out county routinely has a different status from the county around it. What does not depend on any of that: the state electrical permit, the subsurface sewage disposal permit, and contractor licensing. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. Every web address here was checked in September 2026. Offices move and the jurisdiction list changes by design — see the note on expiry below.

THE LIST EXISTS — AND IT IS BETTER THAN MOST STATES GIVE YOU

Most states leave you ringing round to find out whether anybody permits your parcel.

Tennessee publishes it. The State Fire Marshal's Office maintains a single table covering every one of the state's 95 counties and 378 municipalities, tags each with its status, and — unusually — names the inspector assigned to it.

The one address to write down

tn.gov/commerce/fire/residential-permits/jurisdictions-inspectors.html

The page carries its own currency date. When this kit was assembled it read "This information is accurate as of 8/21/2026", and the table held 95 county rows breaking **50 EXEMPT, 37 OPT OUT and 8 SRBP**. Check the date on the page against the date on this kit — if the page has moved on, the page wins.

Read your CITY row first. A county's row governs only its unincorporated area — that limit is written into the statute itself, which confines county action "to the jurisdictional boundaries outside any municipality located within the county." So a city inside an opted-out county routinely runs its own building department.

Four places a county-level answer would be wrong

The county says...	...and the cities inside it say something else
Grundy County — OPT OUT	Monteagle , inside it — EXEMPT

Four places a county-level answer would be wrong

The county says...	...and the cities inside it say something else
Franklin County — OPT OUT	Cowan, Decherd, Estill Springs, Huntland, Monteagle, Tullahoma and Winchester — all EXEMPT
Campbell County — SRBP	Caryville, Jacksboro and Jellico — EXEMPT; LaFollette and Rocky Top — SRBP
Claiborne County — OPT OUT	Speedwell — also OPT OUT; but Cumberland Gap, Harrogate, New Tazewell and Tazewell — EXEMPT

WHERE THE STATE CONTRADICTS ITSELF

The State Fire Marshal publishes the list of state-enforced counties in **two** places, and in September 2026 the two did not agree. We fetched both and parsed them rather than eyeballing them, because this is the sort of thing that is easy to get wrong and expensive to be wrong about.

Two official pages, two different answers

Page	What it lists	Notes
The jurisdictions and inspectors table <i>the one with the currency date on it</i>	Eight SRBP counties: Campbell, Chester, Giles, Hardeman, Hawkins, Lauderdale, Meigs, Smith	Lists Campbell County as SRBP with a named assigned inspector
The apply-for-a-permit page <i>reached from the residential permits hub</i>	Seven SRBP counties: Chester, Giles, Hardeman, Hawkins, Lauderdale, Meigs, Smith	Carries no date. Campbell County is absent entirely

Both pages were fetched and their markup parsed on 2 September 2026. We are not guessing at which is right: the dated table is the better source because it carries a currency stamp, covers every jurisdiction rather than a summary, and names the inspector. **But if you are in Campbell County, or anywhere the two disagree when you read them, do not pick a winner yourself.** Ask the office, get the answer in writing, and record it on the directory page at the end of this document.

And remember the list is designed to change

An opt-out resolution **expires 180 days after that legislative body's next election** unless the incoming body passes it again. The rule requiring a jurisdiction to file "the date of the next election for the legislative body" when it opts out exists precisely because of that sunset (rule 0780-02-23-.14).

So a county that had no building code when you bought the land can have one by the time you pour — and the State Fire Marshal resumes enforcement automatically if the resolution lapses. **Re-check the list before you file, not just before you buy.**

WHERE TO FILE UNDER EACH STATUS

The building permit

Status	Where the permit comes from
EXEMPT	The local building department. Their adopted code edition and their fee schedule govern, and both may differ from the state's — an exempt jurisdiction need only stay within seven years of the current published edition
SRBP	The state, at core.tn.gov , or in person from a contracted issuing agent. State fee schedule, state contract inspectors, state certificate of occupancy
OPT OUT	Nobody, for the building permit. You may still buy a state permit <i>voluntarily</i> and receive inspections and a certificate of occupancy — which is often the cheapest way to satisfy a construction lender

The seven-year currency requirement on exempt jurisdictions is § 68-120-101(b)(5)(A). It is worth knowing because it is the reason a large city can be on a newer code than the state: Tennessee's own residential code is the 2018 IRC, and an exempt jurisdiction may have adopted something more recent. Ask yours which edition it reviews to, and write it down — TN.2 has the line for it.

THE OFFICES THAT EXIST WHATEVER YOUR STATUS

"No building permit" is not the same as "no paperwork." The real risk is not missing an office — it is doing them in the wrong order, because two of them constrain where the house can physically sit.

The sequence, whatever your status

	Step	Which office, and why the order
1	Confirm your status	The jurisdictions table, then your city. Do this before relying on any of the rest
2	911 address	Administered county by county — often a 911 district or emergency communications office. Early: utilities and often the septic permit need it
3	Septic permit	TDEC Division of Water Resources on form CN-0971 , unless your county runs its own program. Constrains the house position — do it before you fix the footprint
4	Zoning approval	A building-code opt-out is <i>not</i> a zoning opt-out. The state permit expressly excludes zoning approval
5	Electrical permit	The state, unless you are inside one of the electrical exempt jurisdictions. Required even where the building code is not
6	Floodplain determination	The local floodplain administrator. Separate from the building code and unaffected by an opt-out
7	Driveway or culvert permit	Decided by the road you touch: a state highway means the Department of Transportation, a county road the county highway department, a city street the city

The sequence, whatever your status

	Step	Which office, and why the order
8	Utility locate	Tennessee 811, free, before any excavation

The septic office list has a wrinkle — use the form, not a table

TDEC's own directory lists **eight** Environmental Field Offices. The septic application form, **CN-0971**, routes to **seven**. We are not going to print a county-to-office table when the two published sources disagree, because the form's own instruction settles it: *"MAIL YOUR APPLICATION AND FEE TO THE OFFICE ASSOCIATED WITH YOUR COUNTY SHOWN ON THE NEXT PAGE."* Page 2 of the form you download is the map that governs.

Two counties run their own environmental health septic programs rather than going through a field office: Blount and Sevier. And Hardeman is split — its septic work goes to one office and its other water matters to another.

STATE-LEVEL ADDRESSES

All confirmed to resolve in September 2026. **We print no phone numbers anywhere in this kit** — they go stale faster than anything else on a printed page, and every office below can be reached from its own site.

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What you need	Where
Your jurisdiction's status	tn.gov/commerce/fire/residential-permits/jurisdictions-inspectors.html
Buy a permit, book an inspection	core.tn.gov — the Comprehensive Online Regulatory and Enforcement System. This is the transactional system
Check a contractor's license	verify.tn.gov — license verification search. Not the same system as CORE , and the two are widely confused
State residential permit fees	tn.gov/commerce/fire/residential-permits/fire-residential-building-permit-fees.html
Opt-out jurisdictions explained	tn.gov/commerce/fire/residential-permits/opt-out-jurisdictions.html
Residential permit questions	tn.gov/commerce/fire/residential-permits/fire-residential-faqs.html

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What you need	Where
Electrical permits	tn.gov/commerce/fire/permit/electrical.html
Septic — field offices	tn.gov/environment/contacts/field-offices.html
The rules themselves	publications.tnsosfiles.com — chapter 0780-02-23 residential, 0780-02-01 electrical, 0400-48-01 septic

Two addresses people mix up. *verify.tn.gov* is where you check that a contractor holds a license in the right classification and within their monetary limit. *core.tn.gov* is where money changes hands: permits, licenses and inspection requests. They are different systems run for different purposes, and conflating them is common enough that Knox County's own homeowner affidavit points buyers explicitly to the verification search.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT**Every office that touches this build, confirmed and dated**

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	My jurisdiction status, and the date I read it off the state list: City _____ Status _____ Date read _____		
☐	If I am inside a city, the CITY's status separately — it may differ from the county's: City status _____ Date read _____		
☐	Building permit office, and whether it is local or the state: Office _____ Local or state _____		
☐	The code edition they review to. Ask — an exempt jurisdiction need only be within seven years of current: Edition _____ Confirmed with _____		
☐	Electrical permit source, and whether my jurisdiction is on the state electrical exempt list: Source _____ Exempt? _____		

Every office that touches this build, confirmed and dated

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Septic: the TDEC field office my CN-0971 routes to, or my county's own environmental health office: Office _____		
☐	Zoning office, and whether zoning approval is needed before the building permit: Office _____ Needed? _____		
☐	911 addressing office: Office _____ Address issued _____		
☐	Floodplain administrator, and whether my parcel is in a mapped hazard area: Office _____ In or out _____		
☐	Driveway or culvert permit — which road authority owns the road I touch: Authority _____		
☐	Electric utility or co-op, and what they need before setting a meter: Utility _____ Requires _____		
☐	I called Tennessee 811 before any excavation.		

The rules are the part you actually need, and they are free. publications.tnsosfiles.com hosts them as dated PDFs — 0780-02-23 residential, 0780-02-01 electrical, 0400-48-01 septic — and the filename carries the effective date, so you can always tell whether yours is current. Statutes are published under contract by LexisNexis at lexisnexis.com/hottopics/tncode. One warning: building and electrical rest on separate authority — Title 68, Chapter 120 and Title 68, Chapter 102. Conflating them is why so many guides wrongly imply that opting out of the building code ends your permit obligations. It does not. Read September 2026.